The Stardust Engine

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Chapter 1: Escape Velocity (Ad Astra) & Main Engine Cutoff (1995–1997)

Main Engine Cutoff & The Magnum Opus

Date: 1995-11-14 at 12:00 America/New_York

12:00 PM — Pulling the Plug (Main Engine Cutoff)

The kerosene space heater in the corner of the rented Blacksburg warehouse clicked and rattled against the November chill, barely keeping the concrete floor above fifty degrees, yet **Ryan O'Connell** had sweat beading along his collarbone beneath his flannel shirt.

Across the room, behind a fortress of analog synthesizers wired into a secondhand twenty-four-track tape console they had bought at auction with the last of their college savings, **Cassidy** stood with her eyes closed and her headphones pressed tight over her ears. For four months, ever since the dust of the 1992 *Friction* trial and three years of corporate blacklist orders had settled over their lives, she had been pouring every nightmare of the courtroom cage—and every dream of what waited above the atmosphere—into twenty-two pages of handwritten staff paper.

At the top of the score, in thick black marker, she had written the title: **"Escape Velocity (Ad Astra)"**—though around the dinner table on Progress Street, the four of them already simply called it ***"Ad Astra"***.

"Six minutes and twenty seconds," **Evan** murmured over the talkback line, his fingers flying across the neck of his bass as **Tyler** drove the double-time snare climb of *Part II: Ignition* toward its peak. "Ten seconds to the cutoff, Ry."

Ryan shifted his hips fifteen degrees in his manual wheelchair—his automatic fifteen-minute pressure check—and locked his left elbow against his ribs as he drove his sunburst Les Paul up to the twentieth fret. The dual-stack tube amplifiers behind his chair were roaring so hot that he could smell the warm dust baking off the vacuum tubes, the overdriven guitar and Cassidy's brassy sawtooth synthesizers climbing together at `11.2 kilometers per second`—the exact velocity required to tear a vessel free of Earth's gravitational well.

During rehearsal the night before, they had tried muting the strings with their palms at the end of *Part II* to transition into the weightless silence of *Part III: The Cosmos*. It had sounded too polite. A rocket stage didn't politely fade out when its fuel tanks burned dry at the edge of space; it cut off with a violent, mechanical snap that threw the astronauts forward against their harnesses in sudden zero gravity.

Ryan glanced down at the heavy black rubber power cord running from his amplifier head to the brass floor outlet beside his right caster wheel.

Five seconds.

Cassidy's voice soared to the top of her register over the pounding drums:

> *"Through the fire! Through the storm! Into the cosmos, we are reborn! AD ASTRA! WE ARE FREE!"*

On the final downbeat of *"FREE!"*, Ryan didn't touch his volume knob. Still holding the screaming high note on the neck of his Les Paul with his left hand, he leaned down over his right wheel, wrapped his right fist around the thick rubber AC plug of his amplifier, and yanked it straight out of the wall socket.

POP—KZZZZT—

Silence slammed into the warehouse like a physical wall.

The red pilot light on the amplifier head died instantly, leaving only the faint, ghostly hum of Evan's fretless bass harmonics and the shimmering, weightless arpeggio of Cassidy's Roland Jupiter-8 floating in the sudden vacuum of *Part III: The Cosmos*.

Across the room, Cassidy opened her eyes behind the glass of her synth rack. A slow, radiant grin broke across her face—the first unguarded smile Ryan had seen on his sister's face since the morning the federal judge had banged the gavel in 1992. She didn't stop playing. Her fingers glided across the keys as her voice rose again, clear and unburdened in the zero-gravity hush:

> *"Look at the stars… no more cages, no more bars… This is the Stardust that is me! The cosmos and the rocket's fire! My one, my only true desire!"*

Sitting in his chair with the warm brass prongs of the unplugged power cord resting in his lap, Ryan let out a long, quiet breath and looked over at Holly standing in the control-room doorway with her yellow legal pad tucked under her arm. They didn't have a major label anymore. They didn't have radio promotion or tour buses or a million-dollar marketing budget, and the multi-state lottery ticket sitting on the kitchen counter wouldn't be drawn for another nine months.

They didn't need any of it. Listening to Cassidy's voice echo off the cinder-block walls of the warehouse, Ryan knew that one day—whether it took two years or twenty—they were going to play *Ad Astra* under the open stars inside **The Crucible**, and sixty-five thousand people were going to hear his sister fly.

Book 5: Burnout Hiatus, Our Own Frequency & The $150M Refusal (2005–2014)

Chapter 1: Our Own Frequency & The $150M Refusal (2008–2014)

Book 6: Reignition & Live at the Crucible (2015–2016)

Chapter 1: Live at the Crucible (May 21, 2016)

Part 1: Protocol T-10, The $15M Lockout & Operation Anvil

Date: 2016-05-21 at 15:00 America/New_York

3:00 PM — Protocol T-10 & The Four-Hour Clock

At `15:00` on Saturday, May 21, 2016, the digital aviation chronometer mounted to the corner of **Ryan O'Connell**'s guitar tech bench inside the South End Zone visiting locker room of **The Crucible** chimed twice.

Ryan didn't need to look up from the fretboard of his 1986 Heritage Cherry Sunburst Gibson Les Paul Standard to know what the chime meant. Twenty-five years and five months after the black ice at **Mile Marker 98** outside Des Moines had severed his spinal cord at the tenth thoracic vertebra, his body didn't run on rock-and-roll time anymore. It ran on **Protocol T-10**.

"Three o'clock, Ry," **Cassidy** said softly from the corner of the concrete locker room, setting down her thermos of warm lemon-and-honey tea beside her Roland Jupiter-8 flight case. Even at forty-nine—dressed in her vintage maroon **CPI Class of 1989** alumni T-shirt with her black leather stage jacket draped over the back of her chair—his older sister still had that quiet, watchful radar that never turned off around him. "Four hours to the seven-o'clock pre-launch check. Have you finished the electrolyte bottle?"

"Last ounce right here," Ryan said, smiling as he set his polishing cloth across the guitar strings, drained the measured sixteen-ounce bottle of water, and pressed his palms down against the anodized push-rims of his titanium manual wheelchair to lift his hips clear of the cushion for fifteen seconds.

On the road, that four-hour hydration and intermittent catheterization clock was the unseen metronome behind every show **The Stardust Engine** played. In a three-hour stadium concert with no intermission, there was no ducking behind an amplifier stack if he misjudged his fluid intake, and there was no forgiving a missed pressure-relief shift when he was locked under hot stage lights with a ten-pound mahogany guitar strapped across his chest. At `15:00`, he hydrated and stretched; at `19:00`—sixty minutes before stage call—he and Cassidy would lock the green-room door for his final pre-show catheterization and leg-spasm stretches so he could roll onto the stage deck at `20:00` with a clear four-hour window through the final chord of the night.

The locker-room door swung open, and identical twins **Evan** and **Tyler Wright** walked in carrying two foil-wrapped trays that filled the concrete room with the unmistakable, mouthwatering aroma of hickory-smoked pulled pork and vinegar slaw.

"Alright, don't nobody touch the talent's guitar until he eats," Tyler grinned, setting a tray down on the flight case beside Ryan while Evan handed a second container to Cassidy. "Courtesy of the **Forger Nation Tailgate Plaza** out in the East Lot. The line at the Smokin' Anvil smokers is already wrapped all the way past the **Crucible Bus Loop**, and the **Blue Ridge Transit** articulated shuttles are dropping off another two hundred students every ninety seconds."

Ryan took a forkful of the warm pulled pork and looked up as their younger sister—and **Engine Room Records, LLC** Chief Executive Officer—**Holly O'Connell** strode into the locker room in a tailored maroon blazer with a CPI lanyard around her neck and an iPad Pro tucked under her arm.

“Let me guess,” Ryan said, pointing his fork at Holly’s tablet. “The ticket brokers in New York and Atlanta are still threatening to sue you?”

Holly’s mouth curved into the razor-sharp smile that had terrified corporate record executives since she was sixteen years old.

“Let them try,” Holly said, tapping her screen to bring up the live gate telemetry from the stadium turnstiles. “As of two minutes ago, all thirty-five thousand Field Level, Lower Bowl, and Accessible Terrace seats purchased through the **CPI Poly Pass** portal are ninety-four percent checked in at the gates. Zero secondary-market transfers. Zero dynamic-pricing markups. Every undergraduate, grad student, and faculty member down on that turf paid twenty-five dollars—or five dollars with their student activity fee waiver—and got a commemorative gold-foil lanyard and a five-dollar tailgate plate.”

Ryan looked at his younger sister with a quiet ache of pride in his chest. When the national stadium promoters had pitched this May 21 homecoming tour finale back in the winter, they had projected a `$15,000,000` gross if Engine Room Records turned on “Platinum Dynamic Pricing” and let secondary brokers auction the lower bowl for eight hundred dollars a seat.

Holly hadn’t even let them finish the slide deck. Citing **Addendum No. 3** to the famous **`$1.00` Perpetual Mutual Cross-License** she had drafted on notebook paper in their kitchen on **Progress Street** in 1986, she had used the **Forger Nation Trust** to buy out all 35,000 lower-bowl and field seats upfront and sold them at strict production cost through CPI’s Zero-Knowledge `SAML 2.0` Poly Pass authentication portal. If a student’s schedule changed, the ticket could only be returned to the portal at face value for the next Forger in line.

“We left fifteen million dollars on the table,” Evan said, leaning against his Ampeg bass rack with a grin, “and there isn’t a single corporate VIP suit in the first forty rows. Just sixty-five thousand Ironheads in maroon and orange.”

“That’s who built this band,” Cassidy said quietly, looking down at her hands. “In 1993, when we couldn’t even afford to heat the warehouse and every radio station in America had our name on a do-not-play memo, it was CPI students copying **The Warehouse Tapes** in their dorm rooms who kept us alive. Tonight belongs to them.”

5:30 PM — Operation Anvil (“Exercise 87-B”)

At `17:30`, after the five-piece **Orbital Crew** touring section—rhythm guitarist **Marcus Vance**, auxiliary drummer **Darius “Doc” Holloway**, synth player **Claire Lindqvist**, and CPI Music Department faculty soloists **Prof. Julian Vance** and **Elena Rostova**—wrapped up line check out on the main stage, Ryan unlocked his brakes and rolled down the wide concrete service tunnel behind Cassidy and Holly toward the Indoor Practice Facility.

Inside, all three hundred uniformed members of the **CPI Marching Forgers** stood in formation in their maroon-and-orange wool uniforms and plumed shakos, their brass instruments gleaming under the high-bay lights while **“The Engine Room”**—the high-tension Kevlar snare and tenors battery—adjusted their harnesses.

When the double doors opened and Ryan rolled in alongside Cassidy and Holly, three hundred pairs of eyes snapped to attention, and a spontaneous wave of applause echoed off the steel rafters.

"**Marching Forgers**, ten-hut!" Director of Athletic Bands **Dr. Arthur Vance** called from the podium before smiling warmly down at the trio. "Class of '89, the field is yours."

Ryan wheeled up to the front of the formation beside Cassidy, looking out at three hundred nineteen- and twenty-year-old college kids who were the exact age he, Cassidy, Evan, and Tyler had been when they recorded a four-track cassette in a cold garage on Progress Street thirty years ago.

"First of all," Ryan said, his voice carrying clearly across the silent practice hall, "thank you for sharing your house with us tonight. Every stadium we've played on this tour has had a bigger press box or a fancier VIP lounge, and none of them—not one—sounds like **The Crucible** when the sun goes down and the brass line hits the tunnel."

A fierce murmur of *"Go Forgers!"* rippled through the horn line.

Holly stepped forward, holding up a single sheet of legal parchment bearing the crimson wax seal of the Commonwealth Polytechnic Institute Bursar's Office.

"For the last eight weeks," Holly said, her voice brisk and deadpan, "you've all been rehearsing a piece of music labeled ***'Exercise 87-B: The Anvil Finale'*** under **Addendum No. 4** to the 1986 Cross-License. And as of `17:30` today, the CPI Office of Legal Counsel and Engine Room Records have verified that across three hundred student musicians, zero cell-phone recordings, zero Snapchat videos, and zero setlist leaks have appeared anywhere on the internet."

The snare line exchanged wide grins.

"Which means," Holly continued, allowing herself a warm smile, "at `00:01` tonight, the **$300,000 Forger Pot** in the CPI Student Escrow Account officially unlocks. One thousand dollars per musician will be credited directly to your Fall 2016 Bursar tuition accounts—with any overage paid out to you as an unrestricted fellowship stipend on Monday morning."

Three hundred brass and percussion players erupted into a deafening cheer, lifting their horns and drumsticks toward the ceiling until Cassidy raised both hands with a laugh.

"Now, there's one reason none of you recognized *'Exercise 87-B'* while you were learning it," Cassidy said, her hazel eyes sparkling. "When I arranged the brass charts in February, I left the lead vocal melody completely off the page, and I wrote a brand-new seventy-seven-second stadium rock overture for the front of it. Out there tonight, at the end of Act VI, we're going to play **'Last Bus Home: Lights Out on Progress Street'** and turn every light in the stadium off. Sixty-five thousand people are going to think the concert is over."

Ryan tapped the cherry-sunburst body of his Les Paul resting across his knees.

"That's when all three hundred of you are going to march right back up the stage ramps in the pitch dark," Ryan said. "And for the first minute and forty seconds of that overture, nobody in the stands—not even the alumni down in the front row—is

going to have any idea what song we're playing. Until `1:40`, when the horns drop out, Tyler hits the kick drum, and Cassidy sings the very first line we ever released in 1987—the way it was *supposed* to sound before a record label in Los Angeles tried to turn us into a synth-pop band."

In the front row of the trumpet section, a senior squad leader grinned from ear to ear. "Wait—*'Exercise 87-B'* is **'Electric Color'**?!"

"In 1980s Stadium Rock," Cassidy smiled. "Let's go blow the roof off the valley."

Part 2: Act I: The Anvil Strike & The Marching Forgers

Date: 2016-05-21 at 19:55 America/New_York

7:55 PM — Five Minutes to Ignition

At `19:55`, parked in the dark wing at the top of the stage-left hydraulic ramp with his 1986 sunburst Les Paul strapped across his chest, **Ryan O'Connell** looked out past the black stage curtains into a sight that took the breath right out of his lungs.

Sixty-five thousand people filled the towering Gothic **Ironstone** bowl of **The Crucible** from the turf all the way up to the highest floodlight catwalks against the indigo Appalachian twilight. There was no opening band tonight. There were no corporate sponsor banners hanging from the balconies—only a sea of Foundry Maroon and Molten Orange, and the low, electric hum of sixty-five thousand **Forgers** waiting for four alumni from the Class of 1989 to come home.

Beside Ryan in the wing, **Holly** stood next to the **Engine Room Films** mobile director's monitor bank, watching the live feeds from the twenty-four-foot counterweighted camera cranes sweeping along the fifty-yard line.

"Look at Camera Three on the accessible terrace at `Section 104, Row A`," Cassidy whispered, leaning a hand gently on the push-handle of Ryan's chair as she looked at the monitor.

On the high-definition screen, the crane lens was gliding three feet above the front railing of `Section 104, Row A`. Right in `Seat 1`, a young man in a custom manual wheelchair—wearing rectangular glasses, a vintage maroon *Electric Color* shirt, and a gold-foil ticket lanyard—was grinning from ear to ear and waving up at the camera alongside a radiant blonde woman in an orange scarf, a tall blonde friend with a pink ribbon in her hair, an athletic guy in a maroon polo, and a dark-haired girl holding a digital tablet.

Seeing another manual wheelchair user right at the fifty-yard line of The Crucible—surrounded by people who clearly loved him fiercely, without an ounce of fear or overwhelm in his eyes—made something warm tighten in Ryan's chest. He remembered how terrifying noisy stadiums had been in 1991 during his first year in a chair, when every stairwells-only concourse and steep ramp felt like enemy territory.

"Put a flag on that timecode for the Blu-ray edit," Ryan told the video director softly. "That kid in `Section 104,Seat 1` goes in the opening montage."

At `19:59`, **Evan** bumped his fist against Ryan's shoulder, **Tyler** twirled his hickory drumsticks before climbing onto the center drum riser, and **Cassidy** kissed Ryan's temple before stepping out into the dark toward her wraparound analog synthesizer rig.

"Have fun out there, little brother," she whispered.

8:00 PM — Act I, Track 1: *"Ignition: The Forger's Call"*

At `20:00` on the dot, the house PA faded out, and a single crisp white spotlight cut through the twilight onto the front-left lip of the stage.

Ryan released his wheel locks, gave two strong, smooth pushes on his titanium handrims, and rolled out alone to the edge of the stage deck.

The roar that rose from the sixty-five thousand throats inside **The Crucible** didn't just hit his ears; it vibrated straight up through the caster forks of his wheelchair and into his ribs. Down in the North End Zone, the galvanized steel bleachers of **The Anvil** were already shaking under thousands of stomping boots.

Ryan rolled right up to his lowered boom microphone, resting his right palm over the strings of his Les Paul as he looked up at the steepest stands in college football.

"Good evening, Blacksburg!" Ryan called out, his voice echoing off the Ironstone walls across the valley. "Good evening, **Commonwealth Polytechnic Institute**! Are there any **Forgers** in the house tonight?!"

The stadium answered with a deafening wall of sound (`"LET'S GO! FORGERS!"`).

"Thirty years ago this fall," Ryan said, smiling as the cameras projected his face across the 120-foot curved LED screen and the North End Zone Jumbotron, "four freshmen and sophomores in a cold garage on **Progress Street** entered a student cassette contest to write a new entrance theme for the CPI football team. Our sixteen-year-old sister **Holly** wrote a one-dollar contract at the kitchen table so nobody could ever take that song away from this school—and for the last thirty years, the only way to hear **'Ignition: The Forger's Call'** was to walk through those gates on a Saturday night."

Ryan lifted his left hand on the neck of his guitar and looked toward the South End Zone tunnel, where three hundred pairs of white spats and brass bells gleamed in the dark.

"Well, tonight is Saturday night in Blacksburg! And we brought three hundred of our closest friends from the **CPI Marching Forgers** to help us open the show! **Crucible—kill the lights!**"

Every floodlight tower in the stadium snapped to black.

In the pitch dark, back on the center riser, Tyler brought a two-pound forged-iron mallet down onto his unmuffled steel brake drum.

CLANG!

Across the entire stadium—led by the student section in **The Anvil**—sixty-five thousand fans slammed their right boots down onto the steel bleachers and concrete decks on the upbeat (**The Stomp**).

CLANG! (*BOOM!*) *CLANG!* (*BOOM!*)

Ryan felt the stage deck flexing half an inch beneath his wheelchair tires—knowing that half a mile away in **Copernicus Hall**, the Geosciences seismographs were already spiking in the green. On the fourth anvil strike, Ryan raked his pick across the open E5 power chord of his Les Paul as Cassidy unleashed the roaring brass-synth fanfare and all three hundred members of the **CPI Marching Forgers** charged up the field ramps onto the stage deck!

Pyrotechnic columns of Molten Orange fire shot fifty feet into the night sky behind the stage truss as Ryan, Cassidy, Evan, Tyler, and three hundred collegiate horns locked into the heavy 128 BPM groove:

> **RYAN & CASSIDY:** *"Hear the hammer hit the steel! Feel the mountain start to reel!"* **65,000 FORGERS:** ***"IGNITION!"*** **RYAN & CASSIDY:** *"From the foundry to the sky, let the molten embers fly!"* **65,000 FORGERS:** ***"IGNITION! THIS IS OUR HOUSE!"***

8:05 PM — Act I, Tracks 2 & 3: *"CPI Tech Triumph"* & *"The Stardust Engine"*

The instant the final E-major chord of *"Ignition"* rang out, Drum Major **Sarah Jenkins** blew four piercing blasts on her silver whistle (`Tweet-Tweet-Tweet-Tweet!`), and **"The Engine Room"**—the high-tension Kevlar marching snare line—ripped straight into the 138 BPM roll-off of **"CPI Tech Triumph: The Marching Forgers"**.

Grinning over at Evan as his cousin locked his four-string bass into the sousaphone bassline, Ryan doubled the century-old 1912 fight song melody on overdriven electric guitar while sixty-five thousand students and alumni clapped in unbroken time and spelled out the call-and-response across the night sky:

> **65,000 FORGERS:** ***"C! — P! — I! FORGERS! FIGHT! FORGERS! WIN! CPI!"***

And instead of marching off the field when the fight song ended, all three hundred Marching Forgers held their formation across the wide stage wings.

Across center stage, Cassidy's fingers dropped onto her analog synthesizer manual, and the shimmering, cosmic 1986 arpeggio of **"The Stardust Engine"** cascaded across the stadium as the 120-foot curved LED wall dissolved from maroon-and-orange flames into a deep-space violet nebula.

Looking across the stage at his sister, Ryan felt a lump rise in his throat. Thirty years ago, when the four of them had written this song in 1986, they had been too scared to even play it for a talent scout, so they had taken its name as their band name instead—**Stardust** for their love of the cosmos, and **Engine** for the rockets to get you there. Later, when Apex Records signed them, the label's marketing department had twisted that name into a cheap corporate gimmick, branding Cassidy as their *"Stardust"* and Ryan as their *"Engine"*.

Tonight, backed by three hundred brass and percussion players from their own alma mater, there were no corporate gimmicks left—only the song that had started it all. When Cassidy's vocal soared into the chorus (*"We are the Stardust Engine, burning through the night!"*) and three hundred collegiate trumpets, mellophones, and trombones answered her synthesizer hook in a wall of live brass, Ryan leaned back against his backrest and bent the twentieth fret of his Les Paul toward the Blacksburg stars.

As the final chord echoed across the Blue Ridge foothills and the 300 Marching Forgers marched down the ramps into the South End Zone tunnel to a standing ovation—leaving everyone in the stadium convinced the marching band's guest appearance for the night was over—Ryan caught Cassidy's eye across the stage and winked.

Just wait until 10:45, he thought.

Part 3: Act II: The Orbital Crew, Not Your Doll & Fifty-Two to Nothing

Date: 2016-05-21 at 20:25 America/New_York

8:25 PM — Zero Backing Tracks & *"Not Your Doll"*

As the main body of the **CPI Marching Forgers** filed into the South End Zone tunnel, a sharp twenty-piece brass and drumline honor guard remained at attention along the upper back tier of the stage, standing beside the five musicians stationed on the stage-left riser.

Ryan did a quick fifteen-second pressure lift on his handrims, rolled back up to his center-left boom mic, and gestured toward the stage-left riser.

"Before we go any further tonight," Ryan told the sixty-five thousand fans filling the bowl, "there's a rule the four of us made in 1986 that we've never broken: **you will never hear a pre-recorded backing track at a Stardust Engine show.** Every synth pad, every harmony, every horn blast, and every drum fill you hear tonight is played live by human hands! Make some noise for our **Orbital Crew**—**Marcus Vance** on rhythm guitar and twelve-string, **Darius 'Doc' Holloway** on second kit and percussion, **Claire Lindqvist** on auxiliary analog synthesizers, and straight out of the CPI Music Department faculty, **Professor Julian Vance** on trumpet and **Elena Rostova** on saxophone!"

The student section roared for their own faculty professors as Tyler and Doc locked their double drum kits into the 142 BPM countdown pulse of **"Main Engine Start"**, with all sixty-five thousand fans counting down from ten to liftoff before the band tore straight into the 1997 title anthem **"Hard Reset"**.

As the final chord of *"Hard Reset"* rang out, Ryan watched **Cassidy** do something she always savored on this tour.

Stepping out from behind her wraparound synthesizer fortress—leaving Claire Lindqvist to carry the main keyboard patch—Cassidy shrugged on her black leather jacket over her maroon CPI Class of 1989 shirt, lifted the chrome microphone off its stand, and strode all the way out to the front lip of the stage directly beside Ryan's wheelchair.

"When we signed our first record contract in 1987," Cassidy said into the mic, her voice steady and edged with steel, "a room full of executives in Los Angeles told me to smile pretty, wear pastel pink, sing the heartbreak lyrics they bought for me, and let them call me their *'Stardust'* doll while they called my brother their *'Engine'*."

Across the stadium, a chorus of boos greeted the memory of Apex Records.

"Well, in 1996, we bought back every single master tape we ever made," Cassidy said, gripping the tilted mic stand with both hands as the 120-foot curved LED wall behind them lit up with a towering, glossy neon-pink porcelain doll mask. "And this is what I told them on the way out the door!"

Ryan stomped his distortion channel and ripped into the snarling, palm-muted hard-rock riff of **"Not Your Doll"**.

On the downbeat of the chorus, twin columns of gold and crimson flame erupted along the front edge of the stage—Ryan feeling the wave of heat across his forearms—while the porcelain doll mask on the 120-foot screen shattered into a million shards of fire:

> *"I am NOT your doll! I am NOT your toy! I don't sing on command for a corporate boy! Cut the painted strings, watch the plastic burn— This is MY voice now, and I wait my turn—NEVERMORE!"*

Sitting two feet to her left, watching his big sister command sixty-five thousand people at the front edge of the stage without a keyboard rack to hide behind, Ryan grinned so wide his cheeks hurt as he traded blistering guitar licks against Elena Rostova's baritone sax.

8:40 PM — *"Fifty-Two to Nothing: The Norfolk Reckoning"*

After dedicating 1995's **"Static"** to the Class of '89 dormitory cassette-traders and saluting Evan and Tyler's decades behind the wheel on Interstate 81 with 2001's **"Midnight Drivers"**, Ryan rolled forward to the center microphone as twilight settled into deep Appalachian night.

He looked up toward the towering North End Zone scoreboard above **The Anvil**.

Every CPI alumnus and student in the building knew the ugly scar from two autumns ago—September 2014, when the **Virginia Dominion University (VDU) Admirals** had walked into The Crucible on Homecoming Saturday and humiliated the Forgers `38–0` in a relentless rainstorm. Ryan, Cassidy, Evan, Tyler, and Holly had watched that game from the Alumni Box, and they had been in the stands down in Norfolk a year later when CPI went into VDU's house and settled the ledger in blood and iron: **52–0**.

“Two years ago,” Ryan growled into the microphone, pointing the headstock of his sunburst Les Paul straight up at the North End Zone scoreboard, “a football team from down by the coast came into our house on Homecoming and put a number up on that board that made every Forger in this valley sick to their stomach!”

Sixty-five thousand fans jeered at the memory.

“Well, last fall, Coach Miller and the boys took a bus down to Norfolk and settled the bill with interest!” Ryan shouted over the rising roar. “And tonight, we’re putting the real score up on that board permanently! This is **‘Fifty-Two to Nothing: The Norfolk Reckoning’**!”

As Tyler and Doc slammed into the bone-rattling stadium stomp and the twenty-piece Marching Forgers brass honor guard blasted the low trombone riff, the massive North End Zone scoreboard flashed a glitching graphic of **`CPI 0 — VDU 38`**—and then obliterated it in a digital explosion of Foundry Maroon and Molten Orange flames, locking in thirty-foot-tall glowing numerals:

> `CPI FORGERS: 52 — VDU ADMIRALS: 0`

The roar inside The Crucible was so loud it nearly clipped Ryan’s custom in-ear monitors. As he wheeled over toward the stage-right ramp during the second chorus, his eyes swept across the accessible terrace at `Section 104, Row A, Seat 1`.

There, backlit by the molten-orange glow of the field LEDs, the young man in the manual wheelchair with the rectangular glasses had his right fist raised high in the air toward the `52–0` scoreboard, shouting every word of the chorus at the top of his lungs while his friends clapped his shoulders and cheered around him:

> **65,000 FORGERS:** ***“FIFTY-TWO TO NOTHING! PUT IT ON THE BOARD! THE FORGERS CAME COLLECTING WITH THE HAMMER AND THE SWORD!”***

Ryan didn’t know the kid’s name, and he didn’t know what that `38–0` afternoon in 2014 had cost him—but seeing the look of pure, weightless liberation on that young man’s face as he stared up at `52–0`, Ryan lifted his right hand off his guitar strings for two beats and pointed a salute straight across the turf toward `Section 104, Row A, Seat 1`.

Closing out Act II, the band dug deep into their 2007 archival compilation **Lost Sounds**—playing **“The Contract”** while Ryan wheeled over to the stage-left wing to salute **Holly**, who shook her head and laughed behind her clipboard, followed by the high-voltage synth-and-guitar duel of **“Steel and Synthetics”**.

And on the final crashing downbeat of *“Steel and Synthetics”*, the master lighting relay inside the stadium press box threw its main breaker switch.

All four towering stadium floodlight banks went completely dark.

Part 4: Acts III & IV: Ad Astra, Cosmic Tidal Lock & Mile Marker 98

Date: 2016-05-21 at 20:55 America/New_York

8:55 PM — Act III: *"Escape Velocity (Ad Astra)"*

In the sudden, breathless blackness after *"Steel and Synthetics"*, the open-air bowl of **The Crucible** vanished beneath the real May stars of the Blue Ridge Mountains.

On the darkened stage deck, under dim blue work lights while his guitar tech swapped his standard sunburst Les Paul for his sustain-modified 1987 Custom tuned for **Act III: *Cosmic Tidal Lock***, **Ryan** looked across the stage at **Cassidy**.

In twenty-one years since Cassidy had written her four-movement progressive rock autobiography in that unheated Blacksburg warehouse in 1995, **"Escape Velocity (Ad Astra)"**—commonly known to Stardust Engine fans simply as ***"Ad Astra"*** when referring to it informally—had never appeared on a live album. It hadn't existed yet when they recorded 1990's *Live in Chicago*, and they had omitted it from the tighter two-hour waterfront amphitheater setlist of 2005's *Live in Norfolk*. Tonight, sequenced in true astrophysical launch order to open the ten-song **Twin Moons** live suite, was the definitive live concert recording of the most important piece of music his sister had ever created.

A warm, resonant voice echoed from the overhead surround speakers across the pitch-black stadium—the **Engine Room Records Planetarium Narrator**:

> *"Good evening, Forger Nation, and welcome to the Engine Room Records Planetarium. Tonight, we leave the heavy gravity of Earth behind. To enter a stable Cosmic Tidal Lock, a vessel must first achieve escape velocity—eleven point two kilometers per second. Prepare for main engine start."*

Six narrow, surgical white searchlight beams dropped straight down from the overhead lighting grid, forming the glowing bars of a cage around Cassidy at her grand piano and synthesizer rig for ***Part I: The Cage (00:00–03:15)***.

As Cassidy struck the ominous, tolling minor piano chords, Ryan watched her shoulders tighten with the memory of the 1992 New York federal courtroom—where Apex Records' attorneys had tried to weaponize their own contracts to seize every song they had ever written, and where their trial counsel had been forced to detonate Holly's **1986 `$1.00` Cross-License** like a legal nuclear warhead, saving CPI's rights while burning the band's commercial catalog to ash:

> *"The Shark was right, the nuke went off! We won the battle, but at what cost?! Sitting in the rubble of a four-year war, Locked behind a heavy, iron courtroom door!"*

At `03:15`, on the downbeat of ***Part II: Ignition (Ad Astra) (03:15–06:30)***, the white searchlight bars shattered outward into a blinding horizon of molten gold and indigo laser light.

Ryan locked his left elbow against his ribs, kicked in his dual-stack tube overdrive, and drove the climbing `11.2 km/s` guitar riff alongside Marcus Vance while Tyler, Doc Holloway, and Evan pushed the twin-engine rhythm section into a relentless vertical ascent. Every time Cassidy belted *"AD ASTRA! TO THE STARS!"*, sixty-five thousand voices in the dark bowl thundered the words back at the sky.

Six minutes and twenty-five seconds.

Ryan looked across the stage at Cassidy. Back in 1995 in the warehouse, he had leaned over his wheel and physically yanked the AC power plug out of the wall socket to create the sudden, violent silence of **Main Engine Cutoff (MECO)**. Tonight, wired into the stadium master relay switch at his pedalboard, Ryan held the screaming high note on the twentieth fret as Cassidy sang:

> *"Through the fire! Through the storm! Into the cosmos, we are reborn! AD ASTRA! WE ARE FREE!"*

At `06:30` on the dot, Ryan stomped his master kill-switch.

POP—KZZZZT—

Every amplifier and stage spot cut to instantaneous, dead silence.

For one heartbeat, the vacuum of space hung over the stadium—and then thirty thousand people in the stands who didn't realize the four-movement suite was only halfway through erupted into a deafening standing ovation, cheering and whistling in the dark because they thought the song was over.

Sitting in the dark on stage-left, Ryan grinned across the deck at Evan. Holding his finger over the twelfth fret of his fretless bass, Evan waited five seconds for the wave of applause to crest, and then let a single, liquid harmonic bloom across the dark bowl to open ***Part III: The Cosmos (`06:30`–`10:45`)***.

At that exact millisecond, the infrared DMX transmitters atop the press box fired.

Across all sixty-five thousand seats of **The Crucible**, every complementary LED wristband lit up at once—transforming the entire human bowl of the stadium into a living, breathing deep-space nebula of swirling crimson reds, sapphire blues, ultraviolet purples, and solar gold.

Even from the stage, looking out from the center of a sixty-five-thousand-star galaxy, Ryan felt his breath catch. Using his volume pedal and an EBow so the attack of his pick completely disappeared, Ryan floated weightless, violin-like guitar swells beneath Cassidy's voice as she stepped out to the center edge of the stage, looked up at the glowing nebula of her alma mater, and sang the words that defined their 1986 origin:

> *"Look at the stars… no more cages, no more bars… This is the Stardust that is me! The cosmos and the rocket's fire! My one, my only true desire!"*

When the full band crashed back in at `10:45` for the triumphant splashdown of ***Part IV: Re-entry (The New World) (`10:45`–`13:03`)***, all sixty-five thousand Forgers raised their glowing wrists toward the stage and roared the closing line in a single, earth-shaking voice:

> **65,000 FORGERS: *"HELD BY THE SUN!"***

As the final golden chord faded into the Appalachian night and the stadium shook with the longest ovation of the evening, Ryan watched Cassidy lower her forehead to her microphone, let out a shaky, radiant breath, and whisper into the live pickup:

"Thank you so much…"

Twenty-six years ago at the Rosemont Horizon on *Live in Chicago*, she had whispered those exact four words at the end of *"If You Walked Away"* when she was twenty-three years old, exhausted to the point of collapse, and terrified of being abandoned. Tonight, at forty-nine, surrounded by sixty-five thousand people who loved her for exactly who she was, those same four words sounded like pure victory.

Without breaking the deep-space atmosphere, the band glided upward through the two interlocking instrumental movements of **The Apoapsis Suite**—**"Apoapsis"** and **"Second Apoapsis"**—into the sweeping vocal horizon of **"The Spectrum (True Color)"** and the indigo planetarium calm of **"Moon 1: Tidal Lock"**.

9:25 PM — Act IV: *Roche Limit & Mile Marker 98*

And then, as the last tranquil indigo chord of Cassidy's *"Moon 1: Tidal Lock"* faded into the dark, the Planetarium Narrator's voice returned—urgent and sharp—as crimson emergency lasers sliced across the stadium bowl:

> *"Warning: Gravitational anomaly detected. Secondary satellite has crossed the Roche limit. Structural failure imminent. Brace for impact."*

Ryan unlocked his brakes, rolled all the way out to the front-center edge of the stage deck, and kicked in the heaviest, most aggressive distortion channel on his rig for **Act IV: *Roche Limit & Mile Marker 98 (Moon 2 — Ryan's Heavy-Friction Orbit)***.

For the next twenty-five minutes, it was Ryan's turn to steer the ship.

Where Cassidy's *Moon 1* used the astrophysics of a tidal lock to celebrate unbreakable stability, Ryan used the **Roche limit**—the gravitational distance at which a moon is torn apart by tidal forces—to confront the night of December 10, 1990 head-on. Tearing through **"Moon 2: Roche Limit"** and straight into the visceral title cut of his 2003 concept album, **"Impact (Mile Marker 98)"**, Ryan leaned into his center microphone while the 120-foot screen behind him flashed highway hazard beacons dissolving into a tumbling spacecraft hull:

> *"Doing forty in the snow with the hazard beacons on, One reckless shadow in the mirror and the highway's gone! We hit a massive fragment in the great unknown— At Mile Marker 98, I lost the throne! We're barely alive, but we survived the night!"*

There was no self-pity in the way Ryan played it—only forty-eight-year-old muscle, calloused fingertips, and the roar of twin drum kits as Cassidy, Evan, and Tyler answered his distress beacon on **"Mayday: The Intercept"** and the heavy power-ballad pulse of **"Star City: Orbital Ward"**, translating his recovery at Star City General Hospital and Evan and Tyler's synchronized *"Freight Dog"* twin-lifts into an orbital rescue mission.

Finally, as Cassidy stepped up beside his wheelchair for the closing sibling duet of **"Twin Moons: Touchdown"**, Ryan locked his distorted Les Paul into unison with her analog synth brass (*"The Engine and the Anchor locking into the groove / We finally found the gravity, we're ready to move! / Touchdown!"*), bringing both Twin Moons down out of the freezing vacuum of space and landing them safely on solid ground in Blacksburg.

Part 5: Acts V & VI: Brother's Keeper, The Summer Festival & Saturday Night Lights

Date: 2016-05-21 at 21:50 America/New_York

9:50 PM — Act V: *Our Own Frequency* & *"Brother's Keeper"*

As the final chord of *"Twin Moons: Touchdown"* faded out and the Planetarium Narrator welcomed the stadium back to Earth's gravity, **Evan** unstrapped his bass, **Tyler** stepped down from the drum riser, and the twins—followed by all five members of the **Orbital Crew**—walked over to center stage, wrapped **Ryan** and **Cassidy** in a long, tight hug, and walked off into the stage-left wings.

The towering stadium lighting rigs dimmed all the way down until only two warm, amber living-room spotlights shone at the center of the stage deck: Cassidy seated on the bench of her gleaming black acoustic grand piano, and Ryan rolling his manual wheelchair right up flush against the left side of her piano bench—hip-to-hip and shoulder-to-shoulder—before clicking both of his wheel locks shut.

His guitar tech handed him his acoustic cedar-top dreadnought and quietly stepped offstage.

For the first time all night, there were no drum kits, no synthesizer stacks, and no hundred-watt tube amplifiers. Just a brother and a sister sitting together in the middle of a sixty-five-thousand-seat stadium as if they were back in their living room on **Progress Street**.

"In the autumn of 2008," Cassidy said softly into her piano microphone, her voice carrying across a stadium so hushed you could hear the May breeze rustling the flags atop the press box, "three years into our hiatus, Ryan and I set up two microphones in our living room here in Blacksburg. We didn't tell the press. We didn't book a tour. We just recorded an acoustic album called **Our Own Frequency** and uploaded it on a Tuesday morning with a one-sentence note: *'We're still here, and we're okay.'* We've never played any of these songs in front of a live audience before tonight."

Sitting shoulder-to-shoulder with his sister, Ryan fingerpicked the warm, intimate acoustic intro of **"Our Own Frequency"**, their voices blending in the effortless sibling harmony they had shared since they were children.

When the final acoustic harmonic faded into the quiet night air, Ryan rested his forearm along the curve of his cedar-top guitar and looked up at the sixty-five thousand people sitting in the dark around them. His throat felt dry, his heart beating a steady, honest `76 BPM` against his ribs. For all the years he had written songs about rockets, Roche limits, and orbital wards to explain what had happened to him on December 10, 1990, tonight—in their own house—he wanted to drop the metaphors completely.

"Twenty-five years ago," Ryan said quietly into his microphone, "after a car clipped our van in the snow at **Mile Marker 98** outside Des Moines and left me paralyzed from the waist down at T10, I wrote a lot of loud rock songs about starships and debris fields because it was easier than talking about what everyday life actually looks like when your legs don't work anymore."

Across the stadium, not a single person made a sound. Down in `Section 104, Row A, Seat 1`, Ryan could see the young man in the manual wheelchair leaning forward with his hands resting on his handrims, listening intently.

“The truth,” Ryan continued, his voice steady and unashamed, “is that the hardest part of a spinal cord injury isn’t the two hours you spend on stage under the spotlights. It’s the other twenty-two hours of the day—what doctors call **ADLs**, Activities of Daily Living. It’s the strict four-hour hydration and catheterization clock we call **Protocol T-10** so my kidneys stay safe. It’s Cassidy and Evan and Tyler stretching my legs every single morning so the muscle spasms don’t lock up my hips. It’s pushing my chair up steep hotel ramps in strange cities. And at night, when the bed in a hotel room or at home is pushed flush against the wall, it’s me sleeping on the inside against the wall and my big sister Cassidy sleeping on the outside edge of the mattress—acting as a **human bed-rail** so I don’t roll off onto the floor in the middle of the night.”

A soft, emotional murmur rippled through the sixty-five thousand Forgers in the stands. Beside him on the piano bench, Cassidy reached over with her left hand and squeezed Ryan’s fingers once before resting her hand on his shoulder.

“In 2008, we wrote a song called **‘Brother’s Keeper’** about what my sister and my cousins do for me every single day, and how I try to be Cassidy’s anchor when the noise and the lights of the world get too loud for her,” Ryan said. He took a deep breath. “I’m forty-eight years old now. Twenty-six years after that crash in Iowa, the physical toll of managing those daily routines on buses, airplanes, and hotel rooms across the world has gotten too hard on my body, and too hard on the people I love. And so I want you to hear it from us first: **tonight is the last concert a touring Stardust Engine will ever play.**”

An audible, collective gasp rose from sixty-five thousand throats across the stadium bowl.

Instantly, Cassidy leaned into her piano microphone with a warm, reassuring smile.

“Wait—don’t panic!” Cassidy said, laughing softly through the emotion in her voice. “We aren’t breaking up, and we aren’t retiring from music! We’re just done living out of suitcases on the road. If you want to hear The Stardust Engine play live from now on… you’re going to have to come visit us at home in Blacksburg!”

A sudden, thunderous roar of relief and joy erupted across the stadium as the 120-foot curved screen behind them illuminated in warm gold lettering:

> **THE FORGER NATION SUMMER FESTIVAL • BLACKSBURG, VIRGINIA • LAUNCHING AUGUST 2017**

“To give the Town of Blacksburg and **Commonwealth Polytechnic Institute** a full year to plan the logistics,” Cassidy announced over the cheering crowd, “starting on the **first weekend of August 2017**, Engine Room Records and CPI are launching the annual **Forger Nation Summer Festival** right here at home! Every August, we’re turning all of campus into a university-wide CPI Open House, turning downtown Blacksburg and Progress Street into a massive three-day street festival

for both signed and unsigned bands, and every Saturday night of Festival Weekend, **The Stardust Engine** will take this stage inside **The Crucible** for our permanent annual homecoming concert and fireworks!"

The ovation lasted for nearly two full minutes before settling back into a reverent, pin-drop hush as Ryan's fingers began to pluck the tender acoustic arpeggio of **"Brother's Keeper"**.

One by one across the darkened stadium, sixty-five thousand fans raised quiet white phone lights into the air—not the programmed computer wristbands, just sixty-five thousand human hands holding up a warm sea of candlelight while Ryan and Cassidy sang their most private truth to their hometown family, flowing directly into 2008's **"Safe Person"** and a stripped-down acoustic grand piano and fingerpicked guitar rendition of 2015's **"Still Your Safe Person"**:

> *"Still your safe person, after all these years, Still the quiet harbor when the world appears. Through the stadium thunder and the bright marquee, You can drop the armor when you look at me."*

10:10 PM — Act VI: *Saturday Night Lights* & The False Ending

When **Evan**, **Tyler**, and the **Orbital Crew** walked back out onto the stage deck at `22:10` to open **Act VI: *The Homecoming Sprint***, Ryan swapped his acoustic guitar back for his sunburst Les Paul.

Because 1989's *"If You Walked Away"* had been permanently banned from every Stardust Engine setlist after the 1990 crash to protect Cassidy from autistic sensory and abandonment overload, they opened the full-band electric return with 1997's **"Echoes in the Wire"**.

And the instant *"Echoes in the Wire"* ended, all four massive **Ironstone** stadium floodlight towers high above the east and west rims blazed back on at one hundred percent power—bathing the turf and the stands in the unmistakable, electric daylight of a fourth-quarter Saturday night in Blacksburg.

"Back in October 2004," Ryan shouted into his microphone as sixty-five thousand fans shielded their eyes and roared at the sudden stadium floodlights, "we gave the athletic department the studio master of a song from our *Progress Street* album to play over the PA between the third and fourth quarters! And we made a vow twelve years ago that we would **only** ever play this song live when we were standing inside **The Crucible**! For the very first time on a concert stage—this is **'Saturday Night Lights: The Crucible'**!"

The entire stadium turned into a fourth-quarter pep rally as sixty-five thousand people jumped in unison (`"GO FORGERS! GO CPI!"`), rolling straight into a jubilant hometown sprint: **"Progress Street: Where the Fire Began"**, **"Neon on the Huckleberry Trail"**—celebrating the paved rail-trail between Blacksburg and Christiansburg where the family pushed Ryan's chair at twilight while the stadium floodlights glowed like neon over the valley—and the 1980s arena-rock punch of 1989's **"Neon Hearts"**.

When Cassidy's warm grand piano intro opened 1987's **"My Anchor Holds"** under candlelight-gold and starlight-white beams, Ryan glanced out toward `Section 104, Row A, Seat 1` while playing the soaring guitar melody. There at the terrace

railing, the blonde woman in the orange scarf had her arms wrapped warmly around the shoulders of the young man in the wheelchair, her cheek resting against his temple as sixty-five thousand voices sang the chorus back to the stage.

After the triumphant charge of **"Reignition: Lights Up on Progress Street"**, the band slowed the tempo down for what everyone in the stadium believed was the final song of the night: 2004's **"Last Bus Home: Lights Out on Progress Street"**.

One by one, the stage lights dimmed until only a single porch-light amber spot remained over Cassidy's piano and Ryan's chair. As the drums and bass faded to a lone upright piano chord, Cassidy leaned into her mic:

"Lights out on Progress Street…"

Ryan reached back toward the standby toggle switch on his amplifier head.

"Goodnight, Forger Nation," Ryan said softly into his microphone. "We love you."

He flipped the switch down with an audible *CLICK*, and every stage light, floodlight tower, and Jumbotron screen inside **The Crucible** cut to pitch black.

Part 6: Act VII: Electric Color & Lights Out on Progress Street

Date: 2016-05-21 at 22:40 America/New_York

10:40 PM — Operation Anvil & The `1:40` Reveal of *"Electric Color"*

Sitting in the pitch dark at center-left stage while sixty-five thousand people cheered into the blackness—and while a few thousand fans in the upper decks began reaching under their seats for their jackets, convinced that *"Lights Out on Progress Street"* was the literal end of the concert—**Ryan O'Connell** kept his right palm resting silently over the strings of his Les Paul and listened.

Beneath the roar of the crowd, he could feel three hundred pairs of rubber-soled marching shoes moving silently up the stage-left and stage-right field ramps in total darkness.

Not a single brass player bumped a bell. Not a single snare drummer clicked a stick. Practicing the exact silent deployment they had rehearsed all semester for **Operation Anvil**, all three hundred members of the **CPI Marching Forgers** took their positions in tiered arcs across the back and wings of the stage behind Ryan, Cassidy, Evan, Tyler, and the Orbital Crew.

After ninety seconds of darkness, **Cassidy** pressed a single, warm, sustained chord on her grand piano.

A lone white spotlight bloomed over her at center stage. Across the stadium, people who had stepped into the aisles froze in their tracks and turned back toward the stage.

"Wait a second…" Cassidy said into her microphone, a mischievous grin in her voice as sixty-five thousand fans roared with laughter and excitement. "You didn't really think we were going to leave our own house on a slow song, did you?!"

The stadium erupted.

“Twenty-nine years ago,” Cassidy called out over the sustained piano chord, “when we were sophomores right here at **CPI**, we wrote a song in our garage on **Progress Street**. When our old record label released it in 1987, they stripped out Ryan’s rock guitars, replaced Tyler’s drums with a drum machine, and turned it into a dance-pop single. For twenty-nine years, you’ve only ever heard their version. Tonight—with a little help from three hundred of our friends—we’re going to play it the way it always sounded in our heads!”

In the dark behind her, Drum Major **Sarah Jenkins** blew her silver whistle (`Tweet-Tweet-Tweet-Tweet!`), **“The Engine Room”** snare battery ripped into a blistering 126 BPM Kevlar roll-off, and every bank of stadium floodlights blasted on in blinding white and gold!

At `0:23`, Ryan kicked in his dual-stack tube overdrive and unleashed the towering, seventy-seven-second **1980s Album-Oriented Rock (AOR)** guitar-and-300-horn brass overture that Cassidy had disguised all semester in the Marching Forgers’ folders as ***‘Exercise 87-B: The Anvil Finale’***.

It was one of the most fun seventy-seven seconds of Ryan’s entire life.

Because the roaring, Van Halen-meets-Journey stadium rock guitar fanfare and three-hundred-piece collegiate brass counter-melody sounded nothing like the glossy 1987 synth-pop radio single, Ryan could look right out across the front rows and `Section 104, Row A` and watch sixty-five thousand die-hard fans grinning in total bewilderment—leaning over to their friends and mouthing *“Wait, is this a brand-new song?!”*

Forty seconds passed. Then sixty seconds. Then seventy-five seconds, as Ryan climbed the fretboard in a screaming dual-lead harmony with Marcus Vance and all three hundred Marching Forgers hit a colossal, stadium-shaking brass crescendo at `1:39`—

And at **`1:40` on the dot**, every guitar, synthesizer, and horn on the stage dropped out completely.

Only Tyler’s heavy, booming 1980s arena kick drum and snare backbeat remained (*BOOM—CRACK! BOOM—CRACK!*).

Stepping up to her microphone at the front edge of the stage, Cassidy smiled out at sixty-five thousand people and sang the seven words every Forger in the valley knew by heart:

> *“Woke up this morning, the world was gray…”*

The sound of sixty-five thousand people realizing at the exact same second that they were listening to **“Electric Color”**—reclaimed at last as a full-throttle **1980s Stadium Rock** anthem—was the single loudest human sound Ryan O’Connell had ever heard on Planet Earth.

And on the downbeat of the first chorus at `2:12`, the DMX transmitters fired the final command of the night.

Across all sixty-five thousand seats of **The Crucible**, every LED wristband exploded into a sweeping, thirty-tier rainbow wave of electric cyan, magenta, solar gold, emerald green, and ultraviolet purple—while Ryan's overdriven Les Paul, Cassidy's soaring vocals, Evan and Tyler's thunderous rhythm section, and three hundred CPI Marching Forgers shook the Gothic limestone walls to their foundations:

> **65,000 FORGERS:** ***"LIVING IN ELECTRIC COLOR! SHINING THROUGH THE NIGHT! WE DON'T NEED NO OTHER—BLINDED BY THE LIGHT!"***

Rolling right up to the front edge of the stage during his `3:35` guitar solo as rainbow confetti cannons and fifty-foot golden Roman candles erupted from the stadium roof catwalks, Ryan looked out across the fifty-yard line toward `Section 104, Row A, Seat 1`.

Down at the terrace railing, bathed in falling rainbow confetti and the glow of sixty-five thousand wristbands, the young man in the manual wheelchair had both hands raised high toward the sky, laughing through happy tears behind his rectangular glasses while his blonde partner and his friends danced and sang around his chair.

Yeah, Ryan thought, bending the final soaring note of his solo toward the Appalachian stars as sixty-five thousand Forgers sang them home. *That's why we never gave up.*

11:15 PM — The Crucible Bus Loop & Lights Out on Progress Street

When the final five-minute-and-twenty-six-second chord of *"Electric Color"* crashed to a halt under a sky full of maroon, orange, and rainbow fireworks, **Ryan**, **Cassidy**, **Evan**, and **Tyler** linked arms with Dr. Arthur Vance, Sarah Jenkins, and the **Orbital Crew** at the front lip of the stage for one final bow before sixty-five thousand screaming alumni and students.

Rolling down the stage-left hydraulic ramp into the South End Zone tunnel two minutes later, Ryan barely had time to set his brake before **Holly** threw both arms around his neck—her immaculate maroon blazer covered in rainbow mylar confetti and her eyes shining with tears.

"Zero leaks, three hundred thousand dollars wired to the student escrow at midnight, and the best three hours of music you four have ever played in your lives," Holly whispered fiercely against his cheek before hugging Cassidy, Evan, and Tyler. "Welcome home, Class of '89."

Thirty minutes later, after Ryan had changed into a dry maroon CPI hoodie and Evan and Tyler had loaded their guitars into the back of the family's white accessible van, they rolled quietly out of the South End Zone service gate onto Beamer Way.

As the van paused at the crosswalk beside the **Crucible Bus Loop**, Ryan looked out his passenger window at the fleet of white-and-maroon sixty-foot articulated **Blue Ridge Transit** buses staged nose-to-tail along the curb, their amber LED destination signs flashing **`CBURG TRANS CTR`** and **`GO FORGERS!`** in alternating letters.

Right at the front bay of the lead articulated shuttle, under the warm amber streetlamps, Ryan spotted the same young man in the manual wheelchair from `Section 104, Row A, Seat 1`—laughing with the transit supervisor in the high-visibility vest before smoothly spinning his chair 180 degrees and backing up the low-floor front ramp in reverse with two effortless, confident pulls on his handrims, followed closely by his blonde partner and his three friends.

“Hey, Cass,” Ryan said softly, touching his sister’s arm in the middle row of the van and nodding toward the bus window. “Look who’s on the lead shuttle.”

Cassidy smiled warmly as the articulated bus knelt, retracted its ramp, and pulled smoothly out into the night. “He belongs right in the front row next August.”

Six minutes later, the van turned onto the quiet, tree-lined pavement of **Progress Street NE** and pulled into the driveway of the house they had refused `$150,000,000` to leave.

There was no tour bus waiting at the curb to haul them to another city at two in the morning. There was no airport tarmac, no strange hotel bathroom, and no alarm clock set for a soundcheck five hundred miles away.

By `23:45`, after completing his final midnight **Protocol T-10** check and stretching his legs with Cassidy and the twins, Ryan transferred onto the inside half of the wide mattress pushed flush against the bedroom wall.

Cassidy clicked off the bedside lamp, climbed onto the outside edge of the mattress—taking her lifelong post as her brother’s **human bed-rail**—and reached across the quilt to rest her hand over his.

“Goodnight, Ry,” she whispered in the dark.

Listening to the crickets outside the open bedroom window on **Progress Street**, Ryan closed his eyes and smiled.

“Goodnight, Cass. We’re home.”